Kalhang & Marem Brine Well Salt-Making

Resource Identifier: CULT-TRAD-007

English Translation: Indigenous Brine Well Salt Extraction & Cake Manufacturing

Category: Tradition | Subcategory: Craft_Metallurgy_Industry

Village / Region: Kalhang | Dialect: Kalhang / Raphei

Contributor / Source: Kalhang & Marem Salt Guilds (Documented in Hodson 1911)

License: Traditional Knowledge Documentation (Permissions: community_authorized)

Seasonal Timing / Occasion: Dry season (Historically central mineral industry)

Ethnographic Summary & Context:

Historical mineral salt manufacture from natural deep mountain brine wells (Machi kong), evaporated in circular iron cauldrons to form flat salt cakes historically used as currency.

Indigenous Tangkhul Text / Chants / Sayings:

"Kalhang Machi kongli tara thuklaka, iram mibingwui lan."

"Machi phungda meili kharong, kazei katha salt cake sai."

"Manipur kaphung konglaoli shailaga, machi thotli lan kakhare."

English Translation & Meaning:

"From the deep brine springs of Kalhang and Marem flows precious mineral wealth."

"Boiling brine in iron pans over hardwood fires to form dense circular salt cakes."

"Traded across the mountains of Manipur, serving historically as high-value currency and food essence."

Procedural Sequence / Observance Steps:

1. Drawing brine water from deep ancestral masonry brine wells (Machi kong).
2. Channeling brine into shallow circular iron cauldrons over subterranean flue furnaces.
3. Continuous boiling with mountain oak firewood until brine evaporates into thick white crystals.
4. Pressing hot salt paste into shallow circular moulds to solidify into heavy salt cakes.
5. Distribution and barter trade across regional mountain markets.

Ceremonial Participants & Roles:

Kalhang and Marem Salt Guilds, Furnace Masters, Trade Caravans

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